CINEMA/OTT

TRIPLE TRIUMPH

With three major releases across platforms, Suresh Triveni reflects on finding creative freedom in the age of streaming

We are not even two months into 2026, but the title for 2026's most prolific creator seems to have been decided already. Filmmaker Suresh Triveni started out the year with the Amazon Prime series *Daldal* (he was the showrunner), and follows it up with the March 5 release of Anil Kapoor-led action drama *Subedaar*, which he has directed and co-written. And he isn't done yet, for later in the year arrives *Maa Behen*, a dark comedy on Netflix, starring Madhuri Dixit-Nene and Triptii Dimri.

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Raised in Ranchi in a Malayali household, Triveni grew up on popular Hindi cinema. Advertising would ultimately see him settle in Mumbai. There, he achieved fame directing the popular 2015 World Cup 'Mauka Mauka' cricket campaign for Star Sports. A prominent feature of Triveni's work thus far has been putting women front and centre, as evident with his debut feature, *Tumhari Sulu* (2017), and his sophomore effort, *Jalsa* (2022). He credits his ability to create compelling sheroes to the "many brilliant women" he has been surrounded with, who have "sensitised" him.

"Back in 2016, I felt there were so many stories about men being written, while women's emotions were hardly explored," he says. It's also why, as much as *Subedaar* is a tribute to Kapoor's icon status, Triveni cannot wait for people to see Radhika Madan, who plays his daughter. Similarly, *Maa Behen* stemmed from the need to do a "mad, irreverent comedy" with three women. The genesis of his projects, he says, starts with his hankering to work with actors of his liking. In this case, they happen to be the OGs of the 1990s. With *Subedaar*, he intends to show Kapoor in a different milieu, one that's "rugged and believable" and in an avatar that's "vulnerable but at the same time strong". "He's a soldier acclimatising to the so-called civilian world. It's an unreal drama in a real word," notes Triveni.

It's happenstance that, after making his debut with a theatrical release, all of Triveni's works so far have had a direct-to-digital release. His heart does pine for the big screen, but he's also practical about the present realities of the entertainment ecosystem. "You need to see the merit of a medium, otherwise you won't grow," he says. "We can crib, or we can figure out a balance between both formats." Ultimately, like every creator, he wants his work to be seen. For now, it's streaming that's giving him the wings to fly. ■

—Suhani Singh



FULL STREAM AHEAD (Clockwise from above) Stills from *Daldal*, *Maa Behen* and *Subedaar*; director Triveni